BIHAR: NITISH IN A SAFFRON MAZE PG 11

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WTO: INDIA LEADS THE PUSHBACK PG 24



SWORN IN Gov. Anandiben Patel and CM Adityanath with new ministers (from left) Anil Kumar, O.P. Rajbhar and Dara Singh Chauhan, Mar. 5

ANI

UTTAR PRADESH

BJP'S RETURN GIFTS

By Prashant Srivastava

Not many outside Uttar Pradesh would have heard of Sanjay Nishad, Om Prakash Rajbhar, Keshav Dev Maurya or Chandrashekhar Azad before election season added some extra centigrades to the warming air. That such leaders of niche, caste-based parties are now highly prized is no surprise in today's hyper-fragmented polity. What piques interest is only how much voice each carries—and uses for hard bargaining during seat-sharing—in alliances that do not always convey the air of being happy joint families.

Two of the four new faces sworn in on March 5, as the Yogi Adityanath government went in for a long-talked-about cabinet expansion, are from these small parties: Rajbhar, boss of the Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP), and Anil Kumar of the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD). Rajbhar, well known for his "pressure tactic" politics, returns to the Yogi cabinet after almost five years. His inclusion comes a day after he criticised the candidature of the BJP's sitting MP Ravindra Kushwaha for the Salempur LS seat in east UP, proof enough that the party doesn't take him lightly. The BJP evidently realises his import in Purvanchal—the eastern swathe of